

Alexandria MT Community Project Guidelines

Objective:

Creating a multidialectal MT dataset covering **14** countries and **11** diverse domains. The data consists of casual conversations reflecting daily life and social interactions, including scenarios such as storytelling, expressing emotions, making plans, service encounters (e.g., in shops, restaurants, public transport, and government services), personal communications (e.g., emails, text messages), and humorous exchanges such as jokes.

Task: Provide high-quality, human-generated dialectal translations across diverse domains.

Countries covered

- Morocco
- Egypt
- Syria
- Palestine
- Jordan
- UAE
- Saudi Arabia
- Algeria
- Mauritania
- Sudan
- Yemen
- Libya
- Tunisia
- Lebanon

Domains

Scenarios from a wide range of domains, including:

- Agriculture & Farming
- Commerce & Transactions
- Construction & Real Estate
- Education & Academia
- Energy & Resources
- Everyday & Social
- Healthcare & Medical
- Legal & Financial
- Logistics & Transportation
- Professional & Workplace

- Tourism & Hospitality

Project Goals and Outcomes

The Alexandria community project aims to develop a large-scale, multi-dialectal, and multi-domain machine translation dataset annotated through crowdsourcing. The primary deliverables of this project are:

- **A Public Dataset:** The final, curated dataset will be made publicly available to the research community. It will serve as a valuable resource for training, fine-tuning, and evaluating machine translation models that handle translation to and from Arabic dialects.
- **A Research Paper:** A comprehensive paper will be authored to describe the dataset's creation, our annotation methodology, and key findings. This paper will be submitted for publication in a peer-reviewed top-tier conference.

Authorship Policy

Participation in the project includes an opportunity for co-authorship on the resulting research paper. Authorship order will be determined by the level of contribution (translation + revision).

- **Eligibility Criteria**

To qualify for co-authorship, each project member must meet the following minimum contribution requirements:

- ★ **Translation:** Contribute **3,000** unique translations that successfully pass the project's internal quality review.
- ★ **Review:** Complete **3,000** unique reviews of sentences translated by other participants.

- **Acknowledgements**

Members who contribute to the project but do not meet the full authorship threshold will be formally recognized by name in the **acknowledgements section** of the final paper.

Annotation Process

1. Tool

To facilitate collaboration, we've chosen **Google Spreadsheets** as an accessible platform for all participants. Each annotator will be given a dedicated spreadsheet. This spreadsheet will include essential information such as the **sentence ID**, the **specific sentences designated for translation**, the **genders of individuals in the conversation**, the **direction of the conversation flow**, and the **complete conversation transcript**.

A	B	C	D	E	F	G	H
conv_id	sentence_id	sentence	dialectal_translation	genders	conversation_direction	participants	whole_conversation
0-7-459		If I apply for a small express loan today with 1 all my documents, how long would it take to get an approval?			female -> male		Me: If I apply for a small express loan today with all my documents, how long would it take to get an approval? Bank Teller: For an express loan, if all the paperwork is complete and in order, you can expect a decision from the branch manager within 24 to 48 hours.
0-7-459		For an express loan, if all the paperwork is complete and in order, 2 you can expect a decision from the branch manager within 24 to 48 hours		female, male	male -> female	Me - Bank Teller	

2. Annotators' Information

Participants should specify the micro-dialect they represent. For example, a participant from Morocco should clarify if they are translating into the **Fez dialect** or the **Rabat dialect** (or another dialect if applicable).

Planned Dialect Contribution		Country of Origin	City	Province
Saudi Arabia	▼	Saudi Arabia	Abha	Abha
Egypt	▼	Egypt	Kafr Elsheikh	Kafr Elsheikh
Egypt	▼	Egypt	Minia/Cairo	Minia/Cairo
Saudi Arabia	▼	Saudi Arabia	Dammam	Eastern
Jordan	▼	Jordan	Irbid	Irbid
Saudi Arabia	▼	Saudi Arabia	Makkah	Makkah

How to annotate?

1. General Rules

Note: Do not use any language models (LLMs) or automated tools for translation.

1.1. Ensure that you **translate into your local dialect**. For example, if you are from Egypt and live in Cairo, use the expressions and style typical of how the dialect is spoken in your city.

1.2. Review the entire conversation for overall context and identify **the domain** you are translating to, for example, a conversation is taking place between a bank teller and a client.

1.3. Take into account the **gender** of the speaker you are translating for.

E.g., the translation of the English sentence "I am waiting for you" to Egyptian dialect is:

- **Male** → **Male:** أنا مستنيك
- **Male** → **Female:** أنا مستنيكي
- **Female** → **Male:** أنا مستنياك
- **Female** → **Female:** أنا مستنياكي

Note: If you encounter a conversation with inaccurate or flipped genders, you can either skip it (by checking the skip box) or translate the sentences as they are. If you choose to translate, please write 'Wrong genders' in the notes column (we will correct them accordingly).

1.4. Ensure the translation reflects your specific **local dialect** (**Highly Dialectal**).

- **✓ Highly dialectal example:** "Whatever, you just have no taste" in Egyptian dialect could be "فكك، إنت شكلك معندكش ذوق في الأغاني".
- **✗ Less Dialectal example:** "I agree in principle, but how do we ensure this flexibility doesn't lead to chaos" "أنا موافق على المبدأ، بس إزاي هنضمن ان المرونة دي مش "هتؤدي لهرجلة"

- For any word, **please write it the way you normally would on social media or in a text message, using its common spelling** (e.g., write "He said" as **قال**) and not a spelling based only on its sound (e.g., **آل**).

2. Code Switched & Foreign Words

2.1. If you feel that the dialectal translation would involve code-switching (e.g., professional workplace scenarios), then the **code-switched words or expressions should be written in Latin script**.

E.g., "Please send the file via email and upload it to the drive." can be translated to "عافاك صيفتلي داك لـ **fichier** فال **drive** فالايميل و حطو فال **drive**."

Note: Don't provide two translations in the same sentence by putting the **code switched** word/s between parentheses, for example: "We could approve **overtime** for ..." **للاشطة الأساسية (أوفر تايم) شغل إضافي** "ممكن نوافق على شغل إضافي (أوفر تايم) للأشطة الأساسية" you should provide one translation, no need for adding the parentheses.

2.2. For **scientific words** (e.g., medication or technical names) that do not have a dialectal Arabic equivalent, you can use the English word.

E.g., "The problem is with the motherboard; it needs to be replaced." can be translated to "لازم تتغير **motherboard**، المشكلة في الـ"

E.g., "Right away. Let me get those for you. So that's three boxes of the **metformin** and two of the **captopril**, correct?". The words '**metformin**' and '**captopril**' are names of medications; these names should be kept as they are for the dialectal translation.

3. Translating Digits & Phone Numbers

3.1. Digits should be translated into **written letters**.

E.g., "I need **2** minutes".

- Translation to Moroccan dialect is "خاصني **جوج** دقائق".

3.2. Phone numbers, emails, and IDs are anonymized. Therefore, keep them in the same format when translating.

E.g., “Of course, my number is **06 XX XX XX XX**.”

- Translation to Moroccan dialect is “**06** الله أودي, النمرة ديالي هي **XX XX XX XX**.”

4. Special Cases

4.1. Some Arabic words don’t have equivalent translations in English. So, the Arabic word is used. For example, **‘خلع’** (type of divorce) in English is **‘Khul’**.

4.2. Expressions such as **‘Peace be upon you’** should be translated into their corresponding dialectal translations. ‘Peace be upon you’ → **‘السلام عليكم’**, **‘God willing’** → **‘إن شاء الله’**.

4.3. If the English sentence starts with **“Hi”** and you translate it as **“مرحبا”**, it’s better to also provide alternative translations in your dialect, especially if there are multiple ways to say “Hi” in that dialect.

4.4. Some sentences may include acronyms or abbreviations—please keep them unchanged in the translation. For example, “We also require a **GOSI** statement” should be **نحتاج برضو بيان من التأمينات (GOSI)**.

4.5. If there’s a borrowed word in the source text that doesn’t have a clear equivalent in your dialect, just use it the way people normally do in your dialect. For example, the word **“taxi”** in English doesn’t have a native equivalent in Egyptian Arabic, so people say **“تاكسي”**, **“تاكسي”**, or **“تاكسيات”**.

4.6. If the source sentence contains an English word that does not have a direct equivalent in your dialect and is generally understood in a broad sense, translate it as people normally say it in your local dialect. For example, the English word **“fuel”** is typically translated into Modern Standard Arabic as **“وقود”**, which is the general meaning. However, in **Sudanese** Arabic, the common term is **“جاز”**.

sentence	dialectal_translation	genders	conversation_direction
Durability is key, but my main concern is the total cost of ownership. What about fuel consumption and maintenance?	المتانة مهمة لكن بتهمني أكثر التكلفة الكلية. صرف الجاز والصيانة كيف؟		male -> female

5. Punctuation Marks

- Regarding **punctuation marks**: translate the sentences and use the punctuation you would normally use in your local dialect. Keep in mind that English punctuation marks are sometimes different from Arabic ones. Check this example from the **Palestinian** dialect for clearance:
 - English**: I wouldn't risk it, **my friend. This** performance usually sells out quickly. It's better to buy your ticket now.
 - Palestinian dialect**: والله لو أنا ما بخاطر يا **صديقي، هاد** العرض غالباً بخلصوا تذاكره بسرعة، أحسنلك إشتري التذكرة هسا.

6. Style

6.1. Translate at the sentence level: Read the conversation for context, but do not incorporate details from other lines or make assumptions beyond the sentence you are translating. Check this Example (From English to Moroccan dialect) for clearance:

Context	Hello, what is the dish of the day? Good afternoon. Today's special is a sea bream tagine with potatoes and olives.	
English Sentence	✗	✓
Hello, what is the dish of the day?	السلام، شنو كاين فالطاجين ديال اليوم؟	السلام، شنو كاين فالطبق ديال اليوم؟

6.2. Level of formality: If the context of a conversation suggests some level of formality, such as between a teacher and a student, you may include a small degree of formality in your translation. However, we emphasize that you should use the same manner you would naturally use when addressing people in such situations in real life. Translate as you would actually speak in reality For example, حضرتك vs. انت. **Example for your reference:**

Good afternoon, how may I help you?	مساء الخير، اقدر اساعد حضرتك ازاي؟
Good afternoon. I've just come from security. I have a food delivery for one of the guests.	مساء النور. انا لسة جى من عند الامن. انا معايا اكل delivery لحد من النزلا
Of course, ma'am. Do you have the guest's name and room number?	طبعاً يافندم. مع حضرتك اسم النزىل ورقم الاوضة؟

7. What to do when you are not able to understand the English sentence or find an equivalent dialectal Arabic?

7.1. Check **Google Translate** for the translation of a word.

7.2. Check **Google Images** for a visual representation of the object.

E.g., the English word 'sweater' in Moroccan is 'تريكو'.

8. When to skip a sentence?

Note: If one sentence is not suitable for translation, then the whole conversation should be skipped.

Other cases could include:

8.1. Sentences contain **Arabic expressions** (written in Arabic script) .

Patient: Does that mean no more ghee (سمنه) in my cooking?
Specialist: We'll need to reduce it significantly and switch to healthier oils like olive or sunflower oil. Small changes can make a big difference for your health.

8.2. Sentences contain non-English expressions that can be expressed in English (e.g., 'si Mohammed' or 'Lalla Fatima'...).

8.3. The entire conversation should be excluded from the dataset if it **does not accurately represent the target culture for various reasons** (e.g., inappropriate scenarios). For example, **Ms. El-Masry**, in the Egyptian dialect, people typically use first names rather than last names when addressing others. So in this case, you should skip the entire conversation, not just the sentence.

Journalist: Ms. El-Masry, can you explain to the average citizen why their electricity bill is going up again?

Government Regulator: This moderate adjustment is necessary to fund essential upgrades to our aging network, ensuring a more reliable power supply and preventing more frequent blackouts. We have also structured it to protect low-income households.



8.4. To determine if an expression is appropriate, consider whether its English translation would be acceptable in a dialectal text. For instance, including "Iftar" and "Suhoor" in an English text is acceptable. However, phrases like "Wa alaikum salam" are not, as they have a direct English equivalent.

8.5. Some cases show that the **Gender direction of the conversation is flipped or** not correct in the correct order to the conversion. You should skip the whole conversation.

Of course, ma'am. Do you have the guest's name and room number?

طبعاً ياآنندم. مع حضرتك اسم النزيل ورقم الاوضة؟

female -> male

9. Checkboxes & Notes:

9.1. For each sentence, you will have 2 checkboxes: '**Skip_conversation**' and '**multi_english_references**':

- For '**Skip_conversation**', you skip the whole conversation if:
 - The conversation is not relevant to the culture and does not sound well.
 - If one of the sentences is not suitable for translation.

H	I
whole_conversation	skip_conversation
Me: If I apply for a small express loan today with all my documents, how long would it take to get an approval? Bank Teller: For an express loan, if all the paperwork is complete and in order, you can expect a decision from the branch manager within 24 to 48 hours.	☒

9.2. If you have some notes about the translation of a specific sentence, you can put them in the notes column.

Note: The 'multi_english_references' and 'multi_dialectal_references' checkboxes will be removed. You no longer need to consider them.

Deprecated:

- The 'multi_english_references' checkbox is checked when you see that the English sentence can be written in other English forms. For example, '**Hello!** You won't believe what happened. Your cousin Mona got engaged!' and '**Salamu Alaykum!** You won't believe what happened. Your cousin Mona got engaged!' has the same meaning; therefore, that checkbox should be checked.
- Check the 'multi_dialectal_references' checkbox when an English sentence can be translated into multiple dialectal variations. For example, 'Hi' can be translated as 'أهلا', 'مرحبا', or 'السلام عليكم'. Similarly, 'Thank you' can be translated as 'شكرا لك' or 'بارك الله فيك'.

J	K	L
multi_english_references	multi_dialectal_references	notes
☒	☒	
☐	☐	